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Submitter Information

Organization: AI & Democracy Foundation

General Comment

In this submission we propose that the administration make democratic AI a key pillar of the AI action plan, and provide context on practical steps the administration can take to support this goal. Democratic AI can enshrine the principles and freedoms that America stands for into the development and deployment of AI systems.

We propose that the AI actions plan prioritizes:

- Rapid funding of research and pilots in democratic AI, e.g., via the NSF, DARPA, and ARPA-E.
 - Use of government procurement power to incentivize the development of a high-quality market for democratic AI.
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Attachments

AI Democracy Foundation AI Action Plan Priorities

Response to OSTP RFI on ‘The Development of an Artificial Intelligence Action Plan’

AI & Democracy Foundation

March 15, 2025

The AI & Democracy Foundation (AIDF) welcomes this opportunity to contribute to OSTP’s efforts to set priority policy actions on AI. Many other submissions are focused on ensuring that America maintains and increases its leadership position in AI, so we will not seek to replicate that here.

Instead, we focus here on what America should *do* with that leadership, *in ways that embed the principles of freedom, liberty, and democracy into the AI systems that will be developed.*

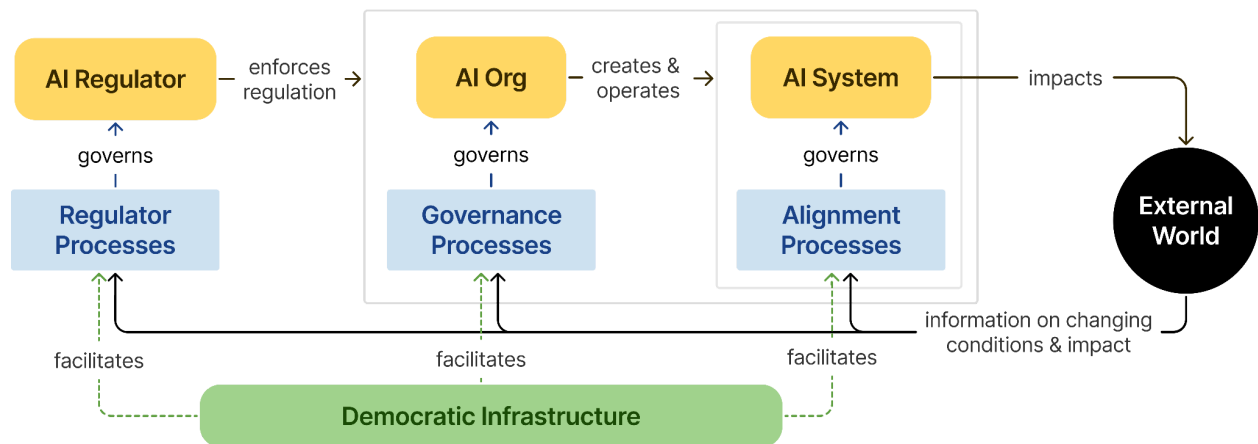
In this submission we propose that the administration make *democratic AI* a key pillar of the AI action plan, and provide context on practical steps the administration can take to support this goal. Democratic AI can enshrine the principles and freedoms that America stands for into the development and deployment of AI systems.

We propose that the AI actions plan prioritizes:

1. **Rapid funding of research and pilots** in democratic AI, e.g., via the NSF, DARPA, and ARPA-E.
2. **Use of government procurement power** to incentivize the development of a high-quality market for democratic AI.

What is Democratic AI?

Democratic AI refers to the use of democratic mechanisms for decision-making about and by AI systems. It relies on democratic infrastructure as shown in the diagram below. Most critical is that decisions about what AI systems do in the world are under some form of democratic control.



Why Democratic AI?

The simple answer is that *democratic AI is necessary if we want the American values of bottom-up freedom, liberty, and democracy to be maintained in the age of AI*. As more decision-making moves from humans to AI, this keeps humans in the loop.

As an example, consider how **Community Notes** on X provides critical infrastructure for collective sense-making, truth-seeking, and decision-making—while reducing political bias. It weaves American values into the fabric of social media. Just as Community Notes provides a bottom-up mechanism for collective decision-making around social media, new democratic AI mechanisms can provide that for a wide variety of decisions that need to be made around AI. We need to massively increase our investment in similar democratic systems as AI becomes far more pervasive across society.

What does Democratic AI mean in practice?

Democratic AI implementations can take many forms. For decisions where relatively little context is needed, approaches like Community Notes can work; for example, Anthropic piloted the use of a very simple process using a similar algorithm to develop an AI Constitution.¹ If more context is needed, there is increasing precedent for **deliberative processes** in which representative groups of citizens are brought together to make recommendations or decisions (supported by facilitation scaffolding optimized for sense-making and truth-seeking). Such

¹

<https://www.anthropic.com/news/collective-constitutional-ai-aligning-a-language-model-with-public-input>

approaches are already being explored by leading AI organizations such as Meta² and OpenAI³. Such processes have also now been tested in extremely challenging contexts⁴.

Recommendations

3. **Rapid funding of research and pilots** in democratic AI, e.g., via the NSF, DARPA, and ARPA-E.
4. **Use government procurement power** to incentivize the development of a high-quality market for democratic AI.

To ensure a future of American democratic AI, we recommend that the federal government include the following as priorities in the AI action plan:

1. **Rapidly funding research and pilots in democratic AI**, e.g., via the NSF, DARPA, and ARPA-E.
 - Task grant-making agencies to prioritize rapid funding for research and development that improves the effectiveness, scalability, and quality of democratic AI, to ensure that our democratic AI mechanisms can keep pace with other AI advances.
 - This should include funding for large-scale pilots of AI-augmented deliberation tools and techniques.
2. **Using government procurement power to incentivize the development of a high-quality market for democratic AI.**
 - Task the Office of Management and Budget to encourage federal agencies to prioritize procurement of democratic AI systems in order to prime the market. AI providers will innovate to respond, and the burgeoning market for democratic AI infrastructure can grow more rapidly.
 - A further benefit is that it will bring greater direct democratic governance by the American people into federal agencies, helping to ensure that they effectively meet the needs of Americans.

To support these core pillars, we expect that NIST will need to develop or adopt rapidly evolving standards.

² <https://about.fb.com/news/2023/06/generative-ai-community-forum/>

³ <https://openai.com/index/democratic-inputs-to-ai-grant-program-update/>

⁴ Konya, Andrew, Luke Thorburn, Wasim Almasri, Oded Adomi Leshem, Ariel D. Procaccia, Lisa Schirch, and Michiel A. Bakker. "Using Collective Dialogues and AI to Find Common Ground Between Israeli and Palestinian Peacebuilders." *arXiv preprint arXiv:2503.01769* (2025).

Appendix

To support the further development of such approaches, AIDF developed the Democracy Levels Framework, which draws inspiration from the levels of autonomy for self-driving vehicles⁵ created by SAE International. A simplified version of the Democracy Levels Framework is included below. As the levels increase, there is a greater transfer of decision-making power to the democratic AI process (i.e., to a representative group of American citizens).

Level	Role of democratic AI
0	None
1	Informs decision-making
2	Fully specifies a decision
3	Binding decisions
4	Automatically initiated given triggers.
5	Constitutional order (where processes can themselves be updated)

AIDF and its collaborators have published an early version of the Democracy Levels Framework and are currently developing a revised version which includes tools for deciding which level is most appropriate, and for assessing the quality of how well a democratic process is (or could be) implemented. We would be happy to discuss these.

⁵ https://www.sae.org/standards/content/j3016_202104/